Name of the nominated Project: **MacaqueNet**

Section A:

Table of all contributing team members (add rows as needed)

We remind the nominator to ensure all under-represented groups are given appropriate credit for their contributions.

First name	Surname	Email address	Primary institutional affiliation (if appropriate)	Contribution roles (describe in a few words)	Approval for the name and affiliation to be publicly listed as a project team member
Delphine	De Moor	delphinedemoor@gmail.com	Max-Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology, Leipzig, Germany	MacaqueNet director, communications and database manager	YES
Lauren	Brent	l.j.n.brent@exeter.ac.uk	Center for Research in Animal Behaviour, University of Exeter, UK	MacaqueNet director	YES
Macaela	Skelton	ms1042@exeter.ac.uk	Center for Research in Animal Behaviour, University of Exeter, UK	MacaqueNet communications manager	YES
Julie	Duboscq	julie.duboscq@mnhn.fr	CNRS-MNHN-Université Paris Cité, Paris, France	MacaqueNet director	YES
Christof	Neumann	cneumann@dpz.eu	German Primate Center (DPZ), Göttingen, Germany	MacaqueNet director and database manager	YES

Section B:

Description (maximum 500 words) of why the Project is deserving of a SORTEE Commendation Award. This may include showing how the project goes beyond simply implementing current scientific practices or processes, and its actual impact on any scale.

MacaqueNet (https://macaquenet.github.io) is a global collaborative community that hosts the **largest publicly searchable and standardised database on animal social behaviour**. It includes data on over 3,000 individual macaques across 61 populations and 14 species, contributed by 118 researchers from 58 institutions in 18 countries. MacaqueNet is a long-term, community-driven initiative to make behavioural data more accessible, standardised, and reusable—advancing transparent and collaborative science.

Comparative research in behavioural ecology faces two major challenges. First, **practical barriers** arise because different research groups use inconsistent methods, definitions, and data formats, making it difficult to standardise or reuse data. Comparative studies are often short-term efforts by individual teams, designed for specific questions and not for long-term use. As a result, researchers often have to repeat the time-consuming work of finding and standardising data from the literature for each new study. Second, **cultural barriers** hinder data sharing. Behavioural datasets typically represent years of fieldwork and substantial investment. Understandably, researchers may hesitate to share their data due to concerns about misinterpretation, being scooped, or the lack of academic incentives for open collaboration. Often, researchers also don't know who they could collaborate with, limiting opportunities for broader scientific partnerships.

MacaqueNet was created to address these challenges. The MacaqueNet cross-species behavioural database archives raw data rather than summarised metrics, with **well-defined protocols for (meta)data standardisation, archiving, and sharing**. Direct collaboration with data contributors helps ensure the data are interpreted accurately. Data sharing is governed by the **FAIR (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, Reusable) Guiding Principles, with community-agreed terms of use**. As a result, nearly 700 social networks across species, populations, and behaviours are centralised in one location. Researchers can request these data to conduct comparative analyses more efficiently and robustly and to address questions that would be impossible to answer with data from a single or few populations. Already, MacaqueNet has facilitated projects on a range of topics including socio-ecology, social complexity, dominance hierarchy steepness, and pathogen transmission. Beyond the database, MacaqueNet is a global community that fosters collaboration beyond traditional networks. We host a biennial event, ***Weaving the MacaqueNet***, which has taken place twice so far: once virtually (2021), and once at an in-person international conference in Kuching, Malaysia (2023). Our next in-person symposium will be held in late August 2025 in Kolkata, India. The community stays connected through an active website, Slack workspace, mailing list, and a newsletter we send out every six months. These efforts help bring in expertise from underrepresented regions, in particular Asia, and support early-career researchers and those without access to long-term datasets—working toward a more inclusive and representative field.

MacaqueNet goes beyond current practices by creating infrastructure that enables sustainable, open, and collaborative science. It directly contributes to improving transparency, robustness, and long-term reusability in behavioural ecology and evolutionary biology—closely aligning with SORTEE's mission and values.

Section C:

Evidence supporting the project (maximum 2 pages). This section can contain copies of photos, websites, teaching/outreach materials, news and social posts, recommendation letters, repositories, preprints, or links (accessible to adjudicators through URLs / DOIs) to any additional documents evidencing the project.

MacaqueNet is committed to FAIR principles across both its database and community initiatives. The MacaqueNet GitHub organisation contains a set of public and private repositories, through which all consortium activities are managed. MacaqueNet's component resources, including an R package for data standardisation, website code, the relational database structure, glossary and data sharing terms of use are all openly accessible. The database itself is FAIR: all data is standardised, accompanied by rich metadata, and the available data can be easily explored through our database search tool. While some data and metadata are fully open-access, most are available upon request through a clear protocol, with every request publicly logged for full transparency. This approach balances protecting contributors (who often spend considerable time and resources collecting the data) with maximising benefits to the scientific community. Further details on specific resources for community and database management are provided below:

Database

Database schema:
All MacaqueNet datasets are accompanied by rich metadata, including the name of the social group, population and species, the data contributors, the period and method of data collection, and accessibility permissions (open access or on request). The database is organized as a relational database, and our database schema provides an overview of all metadata tables and the columns (identifiers) that link them.

Glossary:
Our MacaqueNet glossary accompanies the database schema, providing detailed definitions for every variable. This ensures correct and consistent interpretation of variables, supporting data reuse in line with FAIR principles.

Database search tool:
We developed a search tool for browsing available datasets, accessible on our website, with the option to filter for specific species, behaviours and more. Each dataset has a unique MacaqueNet_ID that users can reference when requesting data. By centralising key information about available datasets, our search tool makes it easy to find suitable datasets and request access. The tool is updated with information about new datasets as they are added, always with full permission from the data contributors. In the future, we plan to add a column indicating which datasets are available openly or on request, with open-access datasets available to download directly from our website.

Terms of Use:
To uphold FAIR principles and ensure transparent, responsible collaboration, all consortium members must agree to the MacaqueNet Terms of Use. This document safeguards data users, contributors and data integrity by setting clear guidelines on data requests, contributions, acknowledgements, and citations.

Data contribution workflow:
Our infographic flow diagram illustrates the full data contribution process, from raw data submission to standardisation and integration into the MacaqueNet relational database.

Data request workflow:
Our flow diagram outlines the full data request process, guiding users from submitting a request to gaining access to the datasets.

Data request log:
For transparency, all data requests are entered into a publicly-accessible request log, showing the name of the researcher leading the project, project title, proposal, datasets requested and current status of the request.

Data request form:
Anyone can request behavioural data from the MacaqueNet database by filling in a request form, accessible via the database page of the MacaqueNet website. In the form, data users can reference the unique MacaqueNet_ID listed

in our search tool (see above). Once we receive a request, we email the data contributors listing all requested datasets, and ask that they agree on terms of use for their datasets with the data requester (or refuse the request, which hasn't happened so far). Once this process is complete, we share the approved datasets as a zip file with the requester.

Data contribution form:
Anyone can contribute behavioural data to the MacaqueNet database by filling in a contribution form, accessible via the database page of the MacaqueNet website.

New data branch proposal form:
The MacaqueNet database currently contains behavioural data, but we aim to expand to other data types including genomic and morphological. Researchers can propose new data branches by submitting a form on the database page of our website.

R Package for standardising and importing data:
To illustrate our standardisation workflow, we created a publicly accessible package with simulated datasets and code showing how we import, process, clean, and check data. To prevent real data being misinterpreted or used without permission or knowledge of the data contributors, only simulated datasets are included. The simulated data provides a safe way for users to explore the data and standardisation process. In line with our terms of use, real data are accessible through the official MacaqueNet request protocol (see data request workflow and form above).

Community:

Website:
Our MacaqueNet GitHub pages website contains information about MacaqueNet, including current projects, symposia, documentation and other news. Through the database page, researchers can browse the database search tool to see what data is available, contribute or request access to data. The code for the MacaqueNet website is also openly accessible via GitHub.

Newsletters:
We keep the MacaqueNet community informed about projects, events and database updates via 6-monthly newsletters.

Mailing List & Slack Channel:
Anyone interested in MacaqueNet or who wishes to become a consortium member can sign up to our newsletter mailing list and get in touch with other consortium members through our Slack channel.

Symposia & Workshops:
Every 2 years MacaqueNet hosts a *"Weaving the MacaqueNet"* symposium that is open to existing members and other interested researchers. These events bring the community together, both in person and virtually, to promote MacaqueNet and facilitate collaboration between members, encourage similar initiatives in other fields, and provide a platform for early career researchers and those from macaque-range countries to share their work.

Fig. 1: Image of our MacaqueNet logo, designed by Sarah Nason from Wapiti Studios.

Stickers:
We distribute stickers of the MacaqueNet logo (Fig.1) at all events for the general public, other scientists and the MacaqueNet community.

Outputs:
All outputs from MacaqueNet projects are stored in GitHub with public access. Two scientific papers involving MacaqueNet have already been published:
"MacaqueNet: Advancing comparative behavioural research through large-scale collaboration"
A paper introducing the MacaqueNet consortium and the database, including over 100 of our consortium members as authors.
"Relationship between dominance hierarchy steepness and rank-relatedness of benefits in primates"
The first empirical paper using MacaqueNet data, investigating hierarchy steepness.